

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 187

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

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Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Authoritarianism • Emotional Restraint

Each powerful person is thus called on to act as a sanctioning agent, and it is essential for him to administer severe punishments to correct offenders' behavior and deter others from committing the same offenses. Husbands beat and humiliate their disobedient and quarreling wives. Fathers whose sons have appropriated cattle without permission have the sons incarcerated by the chief's police and burn down their huts. A father also has the power to curse, but this is used as a threat more than an actual practice. The chief takes strenuous measures with offenders, ranging from incarceration with forced labor, through beating, to exile from the district with a threat of being killed for noncompliance. Many of these severe sanctions are used only when the authority of the person in power is actually threatened; when someone under him commits an offense without threatening his authority, his verbal reprimand may suffice to induce feelings of shame and remorse. In the supernatural realm the ancestor spirits visit death, disease, and sterility on wrongdoers and on those who fail to pay them the proper respects. The severely enforced authority of homestead head, chief, and ancestor spirits is considered the morally correct alternative to an anticipated war of all against all.

[554
Status, Role, And
Prestige](#)
[592
Household](#)
[593
Family Relationships](#)
[631
Territorial Hierarchy](#)
[681
Sanctions](#)
[775
Eschatology](#)
[784
Avoidance And Taboo](#)

Emotional Restraint

This term covers a number of related behavior patterns of Nyansongans, for example, their low degree of nurturance, sociability, and display of affection in situations that might, cross-culturally, seem to call for them. In part this is a function of their explicit system of prohibitions of physical and verbal intimacy with individuals of adjacent generations and, to a large extent, with individuals of the opposite sex. Shaking hands, which might be thought of as a greeting of slight intimacy, is allowed only between generational equals; greetings between members of adjacent generations involve no physical contact whatsoever. Similar restrictions apply to sleeping in the same house,

[152
Drives And Emotions](#)
[561
Age Stratification](#)
[571
Social Relationships
And Groups](#)

09/02/2026, 13:55	Nyansongo - eHRAF World Cultures
bodily exposure and bodily functions, and discussion of topics related to sex and reproduction. A father may not even enter his son's house; an adult son may not go farther than the entrance foyer in his mother's house. In what appears to be a system of rules controlling sexual transgression, severe limits are put on opportunities for informal and intimate contact among persons, including members of the same family.	576 Etiquette 784 Avoidance And Taboo 834 General Sex Restrictions
Even when social equals are in public contact, their interaction displays ambivalence or lack of interest. Boys circumcised in the same year,  188 who regard each other as "pals," consider the joking abuse which they hurl at one another as the most important indication of intimacy. The interaction between grandparents and grandchildren can also be described as playfully abusive. Young men courting girls jokingly threaten them with forceful violation, and the girls roundly insult them in return. One never sees a boy and girl or a man and woman walking together or touching one another in a gentle way. Marital contacts, sexual and otherwise, are not expected to involve tenderness or physical demonstration of affection. Men and women spend their time apart and do not accompany one another even when they are going to the same place; a man does not discuss important matters with his wives. Among persons of the same age, generation, and sex, friendships and cooperative activities exist in a context of polite restraint.	152 Drives And Emotions 571 Social Relationships And Groups 578 Ingroup Antagonisms 584 Arranging A Marriage 593 Family Relationships 603 Grandparents And Grandchildren

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